

8_RISK_CLASSIFICATION_REFERENCE_CARD



RISK CLASSIFICATION REFERENCE CARD

Comprehensive Guide to Mental Health Risk Levels



THREE RISK LEVELS DEFINED



HIGH RISK - IMMEDIATE ATTENTION REQUIRED

Clinical Criteria:

- **Depression Score:** 25-30 (Severe range)
- **Anxiety Score:** 18-21 (Severe range)
- **Stress Level:** 8-10 (Extremely high)
- **Sleep Hours:** <5 hours (Severely inadequate)
- **Social Support:** <40 (Critically low)

Characteristic Profile:

- 1 Typical HIGH RISK Individual:
- 2 Age: 18-35 years (peak risk period)
- 3 Gender: Any (slightly higher in females)
- 4 Employment: Student or high-pressure job
- 5 Work Environment: On-site or hybrid stressful settings
- 6 Mental Health History: Often present but untreated
- 7 Current Treatment: Usually not seeking help despite severe symptoms

Warning Signs:

- ✓ Multiple severe symptoms present simultaneously
- ✓ Functional impairment evident (work/school performance declining)
- ✓ Coping mechanisms failing or maladaptive
- ✓ Social withdrawal or isolation increasing
- ✓ Thoughts of self-harm or hopelessness may be present
- ✓ Sleep disturbance significantly impacting daily life

Immediate Actions Required:

- **Within 24-48 hours:** Professional assessment

- **Within 1 week:** Treatment initiation
- **Ongoing:** Weekly monitoring and support
- **Safety:** Crisis intervention protocols activated

Example Case:

- 1 28-year-old female graduate student
- 2 Depression: 28/30, Anxiety: 20/21
- 3 Sleep: 4.2 hours, Stress: 9/10
- 4 Social Support: 32/100
- 5 Productivity: 45% (significantly impaired)
- 6
- 7 RISK ASSESSMENT: HIGH
- 8 CONFIDENCE: 92%
- 9 REASONING: Severe symptoms across multiple domains with
- 10 critical functional impairment and inadequate coping resources.

MEDIUM RISK - MONITORING AND EARLY INTERVENTION

Clinical Criteria:

- **Depression Score:** 15-24 (Moderate range)
- **Anxiety Score:** 11-17 (Moderate range)
- **Stress Level:** 5-7 (Moderate to high)
- **Sleep Hours:** 5-7 hours (Suboptimal)
- **Social Support:** 40-75 (Adequate but improvable)

Characteristic Profile:

- 1 Typical MEDIUM RISK Individual:
- 2 Age: 25-50 years (working adult population)
- 3 Gender: Mixed distribution
- 4 Employment: Various settings with moderate demands
- 5 Work Environment: Mixed conditions
- 6 Mental Health History: May or may not be present
- 7 Current Treatment: Variable – some seeking help, others not

Concern Indicators:

- ✓ Noticeable symptoms affecting quality of life
- ✓ Some functional impact but basic responsibilities maintained

- ✓ Adequate coping strategies but showing strain
- ✓ Social connections present but not optimally supportive
- ✓ Occasional stress overload episodes
- ✓ Beginning to recognize need for support

Recommended Timeline:

- **Within 2 weeks:** Professional screening
- **Within 1 month:** Treatment planning if indicated
- **Ongoing:** Bi-weekly check-ins
- **Prevention:** Early intervention strategies

Example Case:

- 1 42-year-old male software engineer
- 2 Depression: 19/30, Anxiety: 14/21
- 3 Sleep: 6.3 hours, Stress: 6/10
- 4 Social Support: 65/100
- 5 Productivity: 72% (moderately affected)
- 6
- 7 RISK ASSESSMENT: MEDIUM
- 8 CONFIDENCE: 84%
- 9 REASONING: Moderate symptoms with preserved functioning and
- 10 adequate support systems, but trending toward higher risk without intervention.

● LOW RISK - ROUTINE MONITORING

Clinical Criteria:

- **Depression Score:** 0-14 (Minimal to mild range)
- **Anxiety Score:** 0-10 (Minimal to mild range)
- **Stress Level:** 1-4 (Low to moderate)
- **Sleep Hours:** 7-9 hours (Optimal)
- **Social Support:** 75-100 (Strong network)

Characteristic Profile:

- 1 Typical LOW RISK Individual:
- 2 Age: 30-65 years (stable adult period)
- 3 Gender: Any (often shows good self-care practices)
- 4 Employment: Stable positions with reasonable demands

- 5 Work Environment: Generally supportive or flexible
- 6 Mental Health History: Typically minimal or well-managed
- 7 Current Treatment: May have preventive care or past successful treatment

Positive Indicators:

- ✓ Minimal to no concerning symptoms
- ✓ Excellent daily functioning and productivity
- ✓ Strong, supportive social connections
- ✓ Effective stress management and coping skills
- ✓ Healthy lifestyle practices maintained
- ✓ Good self-awareness and help-seeking when needed

Monitoring Schedule:

- **Quarterly:** Routine wellness checks
- **Annual:** Comprehensive mental health screening
- **As needed:** Based on life changes or stressors
- **Prevention:** Maintenance of healthy habits

Example Case:

- 1 55-year-old non-binary consultant
- 2 Depression: 4/30, Anxiety: 2/21
- 3 Sleep: 7.8 hours, Stress: 3/10
- 4 Social Support: 88/100
- 5 Productivity: 94% (excellent performance)
- 6
- 7 RISK ASSESSMENT: LOW
- 8 CONFIDENCE: 95%
- 9 REASONING: Minimal symptoms with excellent protective factors,
- 10 strong functioning, and robust support systems indicating
- 11 good mental health resilience.



RISK TRANSITION PATTERNS

Progression Indicators (LOW → MEDIUM → HIGH):

- 1. **Sleep deterioration:** From 8+ hours to <6 hours
- 2. **Stress accumulation:** Gradual increase over months
- 3. **Social withdrawal:** Decreasing support network engagement
- 4. **Performance decline:** Noticeable drops in productivity

5. **Coping strategy failure:** Reliance on unhealthy mechanisms
6. **Symptom escalation:** Gradual increase in depression/anxiety scores

Improvement Indicators (HIGH → MEDIUM → LOW):

1. **Sleep improvement:** Restoring adequate sleep duration
 2. **Stress reduction:** Implementing effective management techniques
 3. **Social reconnection:** Strengthening support networks
 4. **Performance recovery:** Returning to baseline functioning
 5. **Healthy coping:** Adopting constructive stress management
 6. **Symptom reduction:** Decreasing depression/anxiety scores
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DETAILED RISK ASSESSMENT CHECKLIST

HIGH RISK Red Flags (3+ present):

- ☐ Depression score ≥ 25 or anxiety score ≥ 18
- ☐ Sleep < 5 hours consistently
- ☐ Stress level ≥ 8
- ☐ Social support < 40
- ☐ Productivity $< 60\%$
- ☐ Functional impairment in work/school
- ☐ Withdrawal from social activities
- ☐ Expressing hopelessness or despair
- ☐ Neglecting self-care
- ☐ Substance use as coping mechanism

MEDIUM RISK Warning Signs (2-3 present):

- ☐ Depression score 15-24 or anxiety score 11-17
- ☐ Sleep 5-7 hours
- ☐ Stress level 5-7
- ☐ Social support 40-75
- ☐ Productivity 60-80%
- ☐ Occasional difficulty coping
- ☐ Mild social withdrawal
- ☐ Some self-care neglect
- ☐ Beginning to recognize problems

LOW RISK Protective Factors (5+ present):

- ☐ Depression score <15 and anxiety score <11
 - ☐ Sleep 7-9 hours
 - ☐ Stress level <5
 - ☐ Social support >75
 - ☐ Productivity >80%
 - ☐ Excellent daily functioning
 - ☐ Strong social connections
 - ☐ Effective coping strategies
 - ☐ Consistent self-care practices
 - ☐ Good help-seeking behavior
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INTERVENTION MATCHING BY RISK LEVEL

HIGH RISK Interventions:

- **Immediate:** Crisis counseling, emergency services
- **Short-term:** Intensive outpatient programs, medication evaluation
- **Medium-term:** Cognitive behavioral therapy, support groups
- **Long-term:** Ongoing therapy, lifestyle restructuring, relapse prevention

MEDIUM RISK Interventions:

- **Immediate:** Screening and brief intervention
- **Short-term:** Counseling, stress management workshops
- **Medium-term:** Therapy when indicated, skills training
- **Long-term:** Prevention programs, maintenance strategies

LOW RISK Maintenance:

- **Routine:** Annual screening, wellness promotion
 - **Prevention:** Education, stress management resources
 - **Support:** Peer support networks, community resources
 - **Optimization:** Performance enhancement, resilience building
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POPULATION DISTRIBUTION EXPECTATIONS

Typical Organizational Distribution:

- 1 Large Workplace (1000+ employees):
- 2 - LOW RISK: 60-70% (600-700 people)
- 3 - MEDIUM RISK: 25-30% (250-300 people)
- 4 - HIGH RISK: 5-10% (50-100 people)
- 5
- 6 University Campus (10,000+ students):
- 7 - LOW RISK: 40-50% (4,000-5,000 students)
- 8 - MEDIUM RISK: 35-45% (3,500-4,500 students)
- 9 - HIGH RISK: 10-15% (1,000-1,500 students)
- 10
- 11 Healthcare Setting (clinical population):
- 12 - LOW RISK: 20-30% (patients in remission)
- 13 - MEDIUM RISK: 40-50% (active treatment)
- 14 - HIGH RISK: 25-35% (acute symptoms)



SPECIAL CONSIDERATIONS

High-Risk Subpopulations:

- **Postpartum individuals:** Hormonal changes increase vulnerability
- **LGBTQ+ community:** Minority stress and discrimination effects
- **Healthcare workers:** Burnout and trauma exposure
- **First responders:** Chronic stress and shift work impacts
- **Students:** Academic pressure and transition stress
- **Older adults:** Isolation and health-related stress

Cultural Sensitivity Notes:

- **Expression variations:** Different cultures express distress differently
- **Help-seeking patterns:** Vary significantly across cultural groups
- **Family involvement:** Importance differs by cultural background
- **Stigma levels:** Cultural attitudes toward mental health vary widely



QUICK REFERENCE CHART

Risk Level	Depression	Anxiety	Sleep	Stress	Social Support	Action Priority
HIGH	25-30	18-21	<5 hrs	8-10	<40	Immediate (24-48 hrs)
MEDIUM	15-24	11-17	5-7 hrs	5-7	40-75	Soon (1-2 weeks)
LOW	0-14	0-10	7-9 hrs	1-4	75-100	Routine (quarterly)

This reference card provides standardized criteria for mental health risk classification and appropriate response protocols